The Sky's the Limit



Having completed an MTech in aeronautical engineering from IIT Kanpur, Valayil Korath Mathews was keen to do a PhD abroad. But a bout of jaundice saw him teaching at the Military College of Electronics and Mechanical Engineering in Secunderabad instead. That chapter of his life ended when his students flunked an exam. Mathews, from Kizhambalam village in Kerala, then joined the technology division at Air India. In 1983, he landed a high-paying job with the Emirates airline in Dubai. The experience helped him gain knowledge in developing solutions for the global travel industry, which was grappling with outdated technology for bookings.

Thus was born IBS Software in 1997, with 55 fresh engineers and one customer. Seven global acquisitions and 25 years later, the company is today among the world's most successful travel tech companies, servicing over 200 clients, including Lufthansa, British Airways, Emirates, Marriot, MSC Cruise, Royal Caribbean, Shell and Chevron. Some 3,500 professionals of 30 nationalities run his business, which Credit Suisse valued at $1.5-2 billion in 2021. Private equity giant Blackstone is an investor.

-Jeemon Jacob

Where he invests profits
"In brilliant ideas and people"

pared to Rs 17,975 per sq. ft in Mumbai. Not only does this help entrepreneurs acquire cheaper land parcels for setting up industrial units, it also makes homes more affordable for their staff. The commute in these places too is shorter, making for a better work-life balance.

Starting 'em Up

The same holds true for the start-up universe coming up in smaller towns. Some of them have made it to the Hurun List too—30-year-old Alakh Pandey, for instance. The founder of PhysicsWallah, an affordable online ed-tech platform, is from Prayagraj, Uttar Pradesh, a college dropout who started with one YouTube channel providing study material to students. Today, his firm runs 27 YouTube channels and 21 offline coaching centres, which have given him a net worth of Rs 4,000 crore. "From only Bangalore and NCR being startup ecosystems historically," notes Gandhi, "nearly 30 per cent of the start-ups today are being built outside the established hubs as per Nasscom's Startup Report 2021."

What explains their success? A ground-level understanding of prob-



ARABINDA MAHAPATRA